

Apples and Oranges

It just works. That's the bottom line behind the success of the Macs. Simplicity and ease of use coupled with flawless integration of hardware and software are precisely the reasons why Macs are positioned to become the *de facto* platform for home digital entertainment.

That's right, when it comes to playing and creating movies, viewing your digital photo collection or listening to MP3 music, there's very little a Mac cannot do straight out of the box. Now think of a PC and you're sure to recollect one harrowing experience after another.

Okay so we're desensitised to driver problems, weird blue screen crashes and system lockups, or trying to figure out how to use a particular feature in that fancy multimedia application. But these 'oversights' are what make most people techphobic in the first place. All PC users can't be expected to invest hours of their time into exploring and working around these glitches. Most of them simply throw their hands up in the air and exclaim, "Bah, this is not worth the effort!"

This is where Apple steps in. In fact their marketing campaign recites similar experiences of frustrated PC users turned Mac converts. And they boast simplicity and a cutting-edge digital entertainment experience as the topmost reasons for shifting to a Mac.

But we all know that Microsoft hates being an innocent bystander. If anything, their business philosophy can be summed up as, "If our customer is hooked onto something we don't make, we start making it!"

Enter Windows XP Media Center Edition. Some might know it as 'Freestyle', but for the uninitiated, this new Microsoft Operating System defines the state of things to come. Not only is Microsoft building a brand new user interface that works seamlessly with a remote control for all digital entertainment needs, they are also collaborating with hardware vendors in laying down the specifications of the PCs that will drive this new OS.

Try connecting the dots. A new Microsoft OS based upon the Windows XP kernel to specifically handle digital entertainment tasks, to turn a PC into a full-fledged home entertainment device where watching TV, DVDs, playing music or browsing your digital photo collection is possible at the flick of a remote control button. And it will come preloaded on a state-of-the-art system that's built under Microsoft's supervision.

The writing's on the wall—Microsoft is all set to hit Apple where it hurts the most. And all Apple can do is to get back to the drawing board...once again.



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